

Windows 7

Microsoft has been working on the much anticipated Windows 7 and the RC (Release Candidate) build is finally out. The initial reaction from online communities so far has been a lot better than it was for Vista. This OS is superior to XP and Vista in many ways. Vista wasn't popular mainly because of the high system requirements. Windows 7 feels like a more optimised version of Vista and it has many well thought of features. It's so light that you can just about manage to run it with 512 or 768 MB of RAM with some of the visual effects turned off. You can find it on this month's DVD. You can burn yourself a copy and get a license key from Microsoft's Windows site.

In this section, we'll be going through some of the major changes and additions that have been put in Windows 7. We'll also give you tips on using these features on the way.

Moving order of applications in the taskbar

There are more changes done to the taskbar in Windows 7 than just the thickness. It lets you change the sequence of applications running in the taskbar. Changing the order is as simple as moving tabs in browsers such as Firefox and Opera. Simply left-click and drag the icon in the taskbar, and watch it slide into place. Another interesting feature is when you try moving the icon upwards, it opens the right-click menu.

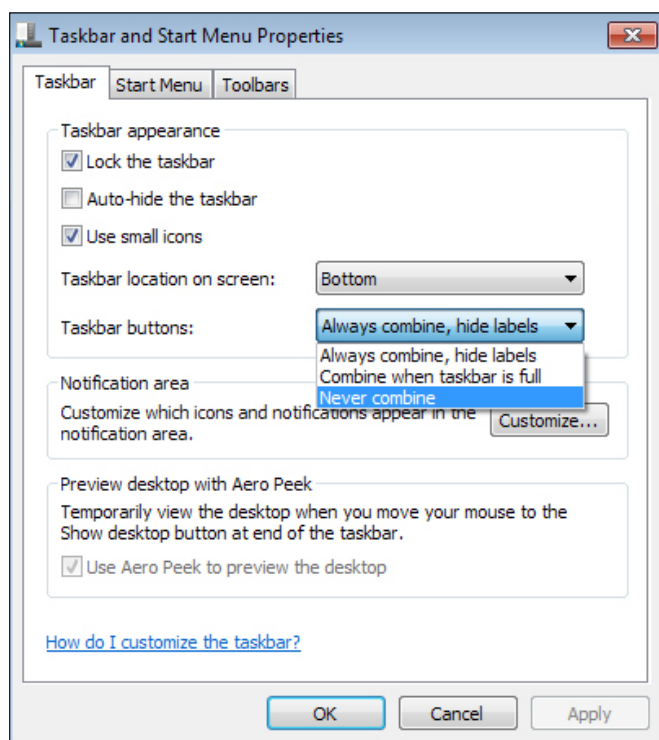
Grouping of active applications

Vista already had this feature – multiple instances of applications were grouped into a single icon to save taskbar space. In Windows 7, the icons are more distinguishable. You no longer have to click; you can simply move your mouse over the icon and a real-time preview of each of the instances will appear. The window can be closed by middle-clicking on the preview. If you like to have the application name appear along with the icon, right-click on the taskbar and click on



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Disabling grouping of applications in the taskbar

Properties. Choose the Never combine option from the menu.

Shortcuts for window operations

Managing windows is also much simpler with Windows 7. You no longer have to use the window controls such as minimise or maximise on the top right. Windows can be minimised using the Windows key + Down arrow and maximised by pressing Windows key + Up

arrow. Windows key + left/right arrow keys fit the expanded window to the left or right side of the screen. This is particularly useful for widescreen users. It lets you fit two windows side by side accurately without having to use the Tile horizontally features from the taskbar.

If you try resizing a window using the corner right up to the bottom of the screen, Window 7 lets you scale it vertically by drawing a faint outline. Dragging the window by the

titlebar and moving it towards either end of the screen will automatically resize to take up half the screen and leave the other half for another application.

Adding additional sources into Documents, Music, etc

Initially, Windows only allowed a single My Documents folder, so users would have to move all of their music and pictures into the specified folders. The other way was to move the target destination of the specific folder to the location on your hard drive.

Windows 7 lets you add as many paths as you want for either of the predefined folders. Simply click on the Start button and right-click on one of the folders – Documents, Pictures, Music and then click on Properties. Click on the Include a folder button and add the paths you want and remove the ones you don't by clicking Remove.

Pinning applications to the taskbar

The Windows 7 taskbar has become a very powerful part of the OS. You can now pin applications to the taskbar just like you could to the Start menu. Even after applications are closed, the icon still remains. It's an easy way to quickly access applications as well as run multiple instances of it.

Many pinned applications also act like a Quick launch menu. Active applications are displayed in this same menu, but differently.

Changing the power button's default function

Everytime you click on the Start button and then head to shutting down the computer, there's always a single button there. Windows 7 now lets you choose the default action for that particular button. Right-click on the Start button on the bottom left of the screen, and click on Properties. Click on the dropdown for Power button action and choose the action. Click OK to save the setting.